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Section Title(S): MARRIAGE AND THE KINSHIP SYSTEM

Hanzwadzi—brother's sister, or sister's brother. We have here a term whose implications give rise to no doubts, and it is its own reciprocal. When a man is speaking it means “sister”; and although those to whom he applies this term may be distant cousins according to our ideas, he must treat them as sisters should be treated according to the traditions and laws of the Mashona. Even a joke with a sex basis made in the presence of a sister involves withdrawal and ceremonial restoration to the norm of conduct.

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Maromo, then, has no thought of marriage with his brother's daughter, nor, indeed, with any girl of his own “Eland” group.

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The term *hanzwadzi*, which is strictly sex prohibitive, is not confined to those of the same totemic group. Maromo's son Musiwa calls Matenda *hanzwadzi* although she is not of his mother's totem nor yet of his father's. She is,

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however, a daughter of Mazwi-ita who is “little mother” to Musiwa. Maromo cannot marry her as she is *mwana* (child), and she is therefore debarred from Maromo's son as she is his “sister”. It is a matter of matrilineal relationship, however, and those of Maromo's Eland group, who are not so closely related as to be concerned in his house, heritage and family spirits may seek an alliance. The one group is probably by tradition *watezwara* or *wakarabge*, that is “fathers-in-law” to the other whose men are *wak'washa* or *wak'wambo* (sons-in-law) and seek their wives among the daughters of the first group whose women they term in general *wakadzi wedu*—our wives.

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We shall see in the Chapter on Totemism the enormous social consequences in the clan system of this extension of thought regarding the forbidden womb of the sister to all the remote relations who are classed as patrilineal “sisters”.

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Some of the ideals of conduct which are stereotyped by the relationship terms possibly shew traces of an older matriarchial system now superseded by the patriarchy (and in spite of the new freedom of women it is still the father who governs the family and the husband who governs the wife—or should do so).

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But take the attitude of Biri towards her father's sister Whera, the *samukadzi*, that is to say, her *samukadzi*.

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